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# Impact Report 2021–2026

## A retrospective

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# A message from the Director

A single sheet of paper, once it is pinned somewhere a family passes every morning, stops behaving like a result and starts behaving like a fixture — and five years ago this School decided that the difference was worth a report of its own.

We began, as the community here tends to, with something small and near at hand: a partner's compliance rating, taped to a corridor board more as a courtesy than a commitment, still hanging there years later because nobody had been asked to take it down. From that one un-retired reading the School built out a five-year programme — the Indicator Commons cataloguing what persists and why, the Living Dashboard learning to notice its own stale tiles, the Impact Pathway Atlas following a number as it travels from the moment it was taken to every decision it is later asked to justify — each strand compounding on the one before it, the whole thing turning, cycle over cycle, closer to a single question: not whether a measurement was accurate when it was made, but how long an institution keeps asking it to still be true.

The honest answer, five years in, is partial — we have got much better at noticing an overdue reading than at agreeing, as a community, to formally retire one. That gap is this report's real subject, more than any of the individual programmes inside it.

Five years is a long time to keep looking at the same sheet of paper. We are glad, on balance, that we did.

Director, School of Continuous Improvement

# By the numbers

Five years, and the four figures the School is asked for most often.

**1,842 indicator reviews completed**

Formal currency reviews carried out across partner systems since 2021, checking whether a published reading still describes the thing it once measured.

**4,380 Capability Sprint completions**

Enrolments across Reading the Dashboard, Stewarding Indicators, and the Sprint programme's other titles, the five years to 2026.

**68 partner organisations**

Government, industry, and community organisations that opened a stale or long-running indicator to the School's review since 2021.

**312 publications**

Peer-reviewed and practice output across the period drawing on the School's indicator-stewardship and evaluation-ecosystem work.

# About the School

The School of Continuous Improvement is the University's measurement-and-process school, tracing its lineage to the former Institute for Measurable Outcomes and gathering, under one roof, everyone who studies how an organisation counts and what the counting quietly does to it. Its six research themes — measurement systems and instruments, evaluation ecosystems, organisational learning and improvement, data cultures and dashboards, impact science, and anticipatory performance — share a single preoccupation: the point at which a number stops describing a thing and starts standing in for it.

Training runs through the Master of Applied Measurement, the School's flagship programme, and through Capability Sprints, its short-course line for practitioners who want the habits without the degree. Staff describe themselves, in aggregate, as researchers rather than by title where a report allows it, and a good share of what they study sits inside the University's own operations — the Adaptive Metrics Lab, the Indicator Commons, and the Living Dashboard are as often examined as they are the instrument doing the examining. This report keeps that reflexive habit close to its centre, alongside the partner work that fills most of its pages.

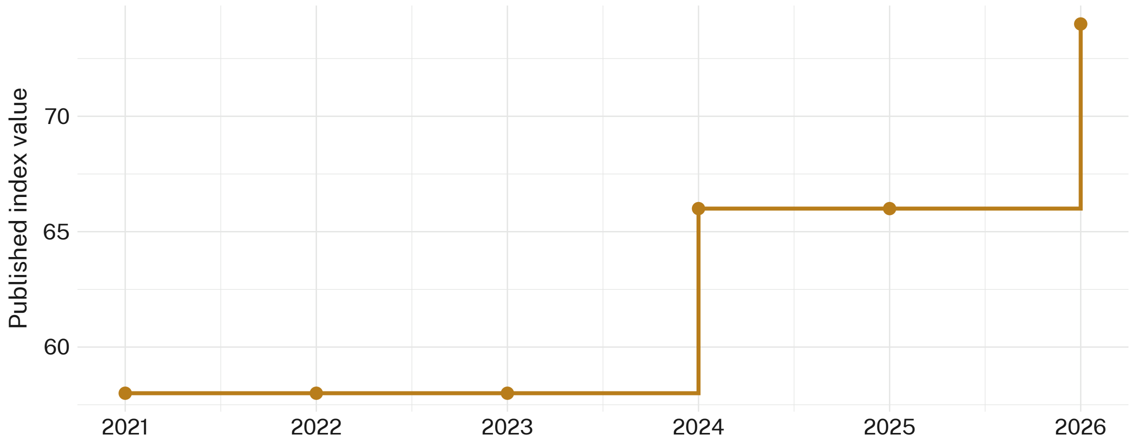
# Where we've made a difference

The four areas below carry the case behind them; where a chart is available, it runs alongside the case it belongs to.

## Instruments that outlast their moment

The Indicator Commons exists to catalogue what an organisation is still measuring and why — not the metrics a partner intends to keep using, but the ones still quietly in circulation years after the review that was meant to retire or renew them. This period the Commons turned its standing method on ratings and scores published once and left running: a compliance figure, a readiness index, a certification level, each still being cited in contract renewals, funding applications, or board papers long after the practice it once measured had moved on. The pattern, once the Commons started counting it, showed up faster than expected — and in places the School had not thought to look first.

Working with a state audit office, Senior Lecturer Renke Sabel's team traced a compliance-rating index the office had first published for a routine contractor review in 2021 and never formally revised. The index kept circulating — cited in three subsequent contract renewals, folded into a risk-appetite briefing, referenced once in a ministerial answer — each use treating the figure as current because nothing about its presentation ever suggested otherwise. When the team finally asked the office to re-audit the underlying practice against the original 2021 criteria, the practice had changed twice in the interim; the index, formally, had not. The office's own review sign-off had lapsed a year before the first of the three renewals that quoted it.




The compliance-rating index as published to the audit office: unchanged for three years at a stretch, revised twice across five — most recently to 74 in 2026, four months after the underlying practice it described had already moved for a third time.

> "A number can be perfectly accurate on the day it is taken and still be doing something dishonest three years later, if nobody has told it to stop speaking for the present."
>
> — Senior Lecturer Renke Sabel, Convenor, Indicator Commons

## The proxy that stayed on the wall

The Living Dashboard is the School's own always-on self-measurement wall, and its researchers treat every tile on it, and every comparable board a partner installs, as an object of study rather than a finished product. A tile is easy to commission and, this period's fieldwork found, unusually hard to decommission: once a reading earns a fixed position on a wall people walk past daily, its removal starts to read less like housekeeping and more like an admission that something was once being watched and now is not.

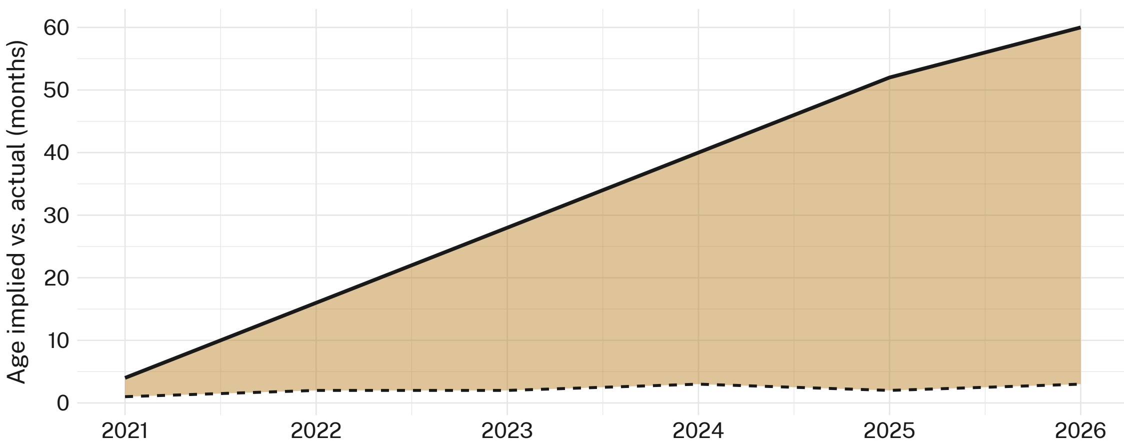
A metropolitan transit authority invited Lecturer and Convenor Marit Osayande's team to review the customer-satisfaction tile mounted in its central control room — a single number, refreshed quarterly when the tile first went up, that operations staff had come to check the way they check the time. The team found the figure had not refreshed in over two years; the survey instrument behind it had been discontinued, its contractor reassigned, and nobody in the control room had noticed, because the number on the wall had never stopped looking current. Staff described adjusting rostering and complaint-escalation decisions around a figure that, for the better part of two years, had simply been sitting there.

> "Nobody lied to us about the number. It just stopped being anyone's job to keep it honest, and the wall never said so."
>
> — Control Room Supervisor, a metropolitan transit authority

## What a number is asked to keep meaning

The Impact Pathway Atlas exists to trace how a piece of research effort becomes counted, valued, and eventually cited work — the usual pathway runs forward, from a finding to its recognition. This period Senior Research Fellow Sten Okwuosa's team ran the Atlas's method in reverse on a single class of object: a customer-facing score, taken once for a specific purpose, and asked by everyone downstream to keep meaning the same thing indefinitely.

A national telecommunications carrier had first measured a customer-trust score for a single marketing campaign in 2022, using a bespoke short-form survey run once, to a sample of respondents who saw one advertisement. Four years on, the same figure was still appearing in board papers, investor briefings, and a customer-facing trust page on the carrier's website — each new citation treating the score as if it had just been taken, none of them noting the year, the sample, or the campaign it was built to evaluate. The Atlas team's pathway map showed the score picking up eleven distinct downstream citations, only one of which linked back to the original survey instrument.




The age a customer-trust score's presentation implies, against the actual age of the measurement behind it. By 2026 a score last taken sixty months earlier was still presented with an implied age of three months.

> "A score doesn't announce its own expiry. Somebody has to keep asking it how old it actually is, and for four years nobody at the carrier had that job."
>
> — Senior Research Fellow Sten Okwuosa, Convenor, Impact Pathway Atlas

## Retiring a reading, formally

Evaluation of Evaluation asks what a review actually changes, as distinct from what it merely re-certifies; applied to metric stewardship, this period's strand of that programme asked a narrower version of the same question — what does it take, procedurally, for an organisation to formally retire a reading it has stopped needing. Lecturer and Convenor Dagny Okafor's team found the honest answer was almost always: more than deciding the number is no longer useful.

A chronic-disease foundation had carried a single wellbeing-index item in its annual report for eleven years, unchanged since the underlying survey instrument it drew from was substituted for a longer, better-validated one in the report's third year. The item stayed because retiring it required an explicit board resolution nobody had thought to draft, and because the annual report's template treated the item as a fixed row rather than a chosen one. Working with the School, the foundation drafted its first formal retirement protocol: a standing annual prompt requiring every legacy indicator to be re-justified in writing or struck from the template, with the item in question the protocol's first formal retirement.

> "Nobody ever votes to keep a stale indicator. It survives because retiring it was never anybody's job description, and giving it one turned out to be most of the fix."
>
> — Dr Dagny Okafor, Convenor, Evaluation of Evaluation

# Where we're headed

Over the next planning period, the Indicator Commons will extend the currency-review method this report describes into a standing annual cycle rather than a one-off audit: every indicator a partner organisation asks the School to catalogue will carry a re-justification date, after which its continued publication requires an explicit sign-off rather than simple inertia. The Living Dashboard will pilot an automatic staleness flag on its own tiles, so that a reading past its refresh window declares itself rather than waiting for a researcher to notice by chance.

The Impact Pathway Atlas will build out its reverse-pathway method — tracing a single reading forward through every downstream citation it accrues — into a service the School offers partner organisations directly, rather than a technique reserved for its own research programme; the telecommunications-sector pilot behind this report's third finding is the template. Evaluation of Evaluation will take the chronic-disease foundation's retirement protocol as a model and test whether a written re-justification requirement changes retirement behaviour more broadly, or simply relocates the same reluctance into a different form.

None of this promises that fewer readings will outlive their moment. Measurement, done honestly, keeps producing more readings than any organisation gets around to retiring, and the School expects that imbalance to persist well past this reporting period. Its more modest aim is to make the moment a reading goes stale a little harder to miss, and a little easier, once noticed, to actually act on.

# With thanks

This report draws on the cooperation of partner organisations across government, industry, and the community sector who opened long-running or stale indicators to the School's review, several of them mid-way through a renewal or an audit of their own. We thank the dozens of staff who located the original survey instrument behind a decade-old figure, dug a superseded rating out of an archive, or simply admitted that nobody currently owned a number their organisation still quoted.

We are grateful to the reviewers, internal and external, who read this report's case studies before either the readings or the retirements they describe reached a board table. And we thank the wider University community for its patience with a School that spent a portion of this reporting period asking its own dashboards the same uncomfortable question it was asking everyone else's: how do you know that's still true.

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